

The Feynman technique

Explain it in writing to a twelve-year-old. Where you stall, you don't understand it yet. Go back for exactly that, and try again.

FOR A SKILL · AFTER RICHARD FEYNMAN; THE FOUR STEPS FROM AROUND 2011 · TAKES HALF AN HOUR PER IDEA

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write the idea at the top of a blank page.
One idea, not a chapter.
2. Explain it, in writing, as if to a bright twelve-year-old who will ask "why?" at every step. Plain words. No jargon unless you define it as you go.
3. Read it back and mark every place you stalled, waved your hands, or used a word you couldn't define. Those marks are the list of what you don't yet understand.
4. Go back to the source for those gaps only. Not the whole chapter: the exact things you marked.
5. Rewrite the explanation. Simplify, and find one analogy that a twelve-year-old would get. If the analogy breaks, note where.
6. Say it out loud to someone, or to the wall. If it still doesn't come out plain, repeat from step 3.

Where it falls down. Explaining it to yourself, who already lets you get away with the hand-waving.

WITH A PEN

The idea

One, at the top

Explain it to a twelve-year-old

In writing. Plain words. They will ask why at every step

Where I stalled or reached for jargon

The list of what I don't understand yet

Back to the source, for these only

The simple version, with one analogy

And where the analogy breaks

Named for Richard Feynman, the physicist who insisted that if you can't explain a thing simply you don't understand it, and who worked that way himself. He never wrote it up as a method. The four-step version circulating now was set down by Scott Young around 2011, and that is worth knowing so the name carries the right weight.

On paper only, for now: greggle.app/kinds/